



United we stand: The public outcry over the Jessica Lal murder case is an exemplary case of civic activism in India

Civic Sense

AS A PEOPLE, WE HAVE THIS HABIT OF ACCEPTING EVERYTHING AND NOT EXPECTING BETTER: FROM OURSELVES, FROM OUR SURROUNDINGS, FROM OUR POLITICIANS, JUDGES, THE POLICE, AND THOSE WHO GOVERN US.

complaining about queues at airports being long. If your city gets a new airport that helps people travel comfortably, then you've got to accept that it may require you to take a 25-km journey to get to it. As a people, we need to be more involved in our surroundings and every thing that we do. Only then can we demand more and get what we deserve from our government and our politicians. It involves an effort, some sacrifice of time and a giving of one's self. We're all interested in knowing what's happening in the lives of people around us (and in the latest soap on television) but how much do we care to know about our local councillors or ward officers? Who do we vote for when we do bother to vote? Parties? Individuals? How do we decide? All of us know the names and faces of the national-level politicians. I'm not sure that most of us know who our municipal representative is.

As citizens, it should be our business to find out how our local governments are run, it will give us the right to demand better governance from them. We need to find out about candidates who stand for elections, who they are and why they deserve to be voted in or out. The choices we make eventually reflect what we expect of those who represent us in government. If people vote for good candidates with track records of performance, it will force parties to field people of a certain calibre. Performances in cricket are easily

followed through statistics in the papers—the performance of people who impact our lives more directly requires a little more effort.

Our level of involvement tends to be sporadic. It must be proactive, more committed. Only then do you earn the right to demand, to expect and not accept. Take my own field for example. Indians need to engage with sport more than we do. We need to understand what our athletes go through, understand how legitimate their demands are for better facilities and better standards of training. What happens is that once every four years, we tend to stick our heads up and demand Olympic medals.

Demanding better means taking responsibility for your demands—following them through from start to finish, being committed to more than just yourself. We have to start by demanding more of ourselves first no matter what field we work in, in whatever we do. We could be doctors, lawyers or sportsmen. We must want to be best we can be. We must remember that not everyone in India has equal opportunities through something as basic as an accident of birth, at other times, plain bad luck. A lot of people do not have the chance and therefore for those who do, it becomes more important that they make the absolute best of what they have.

The author is one of Indian cricket's all-time greats.